

Sociology Assignment – 01
by
Sharjeel
L1F24BSCS0506

Instructor: Marriam Arshad

Introduction

Sociology, at its core, is the scientific study of human society and social behavior. To make sense of the complex relationships, institutions, and inequalities that shape everyday life, sociologists rely on theoretical frameworks known as sociological perspectives. These perspectives bring a different part of social reality into focus.

There are three major sociological perspectives in this field:

- ◆ Structural Functionalism,
- ◆ Social Conflict Theory
- ◆ Symbolic Interactionism

Each offers a unique way of understanding how society works, why problems exist, and how individuals relate to the larger social world around them.

1. Structural Functionalism

Core Idea

Structural Functionalism is a macro-level theoretical perspective that views society as a complex system of interrelated parts, each of which serves a specific function to maintain overall stability and order. Just as the organs of a human body work together to keep a person alive, the institutions of society, such as family, education, religion, government, and the economy, each play a vital role in keeping society functioning smoothly.

The foundational thinker behind this perspective include **Auguste Comte**, who is also known as the father of sociology and introduced the idea of studying society as a system. According to him, there are three stages of society:

- ***Theological stage, Metaphysical stage, Scientific stage***

Others include **Herbert Spencer**, who compared society to a living organism and emphasized its evolutionary nature and **Emile Durkheim**, who explored how social facts and shared values create a sense of collective solidarity. Sociologists believe that social norms and values regulate individual behavior, and that order is maintained through **consensus, cooperation, and shared beliefs**.

Present-Day Examples

From a structural functionalist perspective, Mosques in Pakistan serve beyond religious worship; they function as community centers for announcements, dispute resolution, and charity distribution (zakat). They maintain social solidarity and moral order at the neighborhood level.

Another example is the traditional Pakistani joint family functions as a built-in welfare system. Elders provide childcare, working members pool income, and the sick are cared for at home, each member plays a role that keeps the unit stable without needing state support.

2. Social Conflict Theory

Core Idea

Social Conflict Theory offers a different picture of society. Rather than seeing society as a well-functioning system, this perspective argues that society is fundamentally defined by competition and conflict. Individuals and groups are constantly competing for limited resources like wealth, power, status, and opportunities and those who hold power use it to maintain their dominance over those who do not.

Karl Marx is the most prominent figure associated with this perspective. He argued that society is divided into two primary classes: **the Bourgeoisie** (the capitalist class who own the means of production) and the **Proletariat** (the working class who sell their labor). He believed that this class division always leads to exploitation and conflict, and that true social change requires the systems to stop allowing the elite to maintain power over the majority.

Social Conflict Theory is also divided into sub-approaches like the *Gender Conflict Approach* examines inequality between men and women, while the *Race Conflict Approach* focuses on racial and ethnic discrimination.

Harriet Martineau, a British sociologist, was an early advocate who wrote extensively about discrimination based on gender and race.

Present-Day Examples

A contemporary example of Social Conflict Theory in action is the rise of the gig economy like Uber, Careem, Foodpanda, and similar **capitalist organizations** across the world. On the surface, these platforms offer workers flexibility and independence. In reality, however, the conflict perspective reveals a deeper power imbalance. The platform owners (Bourgeoisie) generate enormous profits while gig workers (Proletariat) bear all the financial risk, receive no benefits such as health insurance or pension, and earn wages that *barely cover basic living costs*.

Another examples is of powerful landlords (waderas) controlling land, water, and even votes of poor farmers who work that land for generations without owning any of it. This is a living example of the Bourgeoisie-Proletariat divide, wealth and power locked in the hands of a few, passed down through bloodlines.

3. Symbolic Interactionism

Core Idea

While Structural Functionalism and Social Conflict Theory both take a macro-level view of society, Symbolic Interactionism focus at the micro level. It focuses on the everyday interactions between individuals and how these interactions create and maintain social reality. According to this perspective, society is not a fixed structure but a dynamic, ongoing process that it is continually produced and reproduced through human communication and interaction.

Symbolic Interactionists are interested in the symbols that people use to communicate, language, gestures, facial expressions, clothing, and even silence. These symbols carry shared meanings that people use to interpret the world around them. When two people interact, they are constantly interpreting each other's symbols and adjusting their own behavior in response.

George Herbert Mead is considered a founding figure of this perspective, having emphasized the role of language and social interaction in the development of the self.

Present-Day Examples

Social media platforms are perhaps the most vivid modern instances of Symbolic Interactionism. Every post, caption, profile picture, and story is a carefully chosen symbol through which individuals construct and communicate their identity to the world. The likes, comments, and shares they receive are social responses that validate or challenge that identity, prompting users to adjust their self-presentation in future interactions. A person might present one version of themselves on a public account and an entirely different version on a private "burner account".

A woman wearing a hijab vs. western clothing in Pakistan is immediately assigned different social meanings by those around her, pious, modern, rebellious, traditional. These labels aren't based on conversation; they're based entirely on the symbol of clothing, showing how appearance drives social interaction.

Comparing the Three Perspectives

All three perspectives offer valuable but distinct ways of understanding society. Structural Functionalism helps us appreciate the interdependence of social institutions and why stability matters. Social Conflict Theory forces us to confront the inequalities and power struggles that Functionalism tends to overlook. Symbolic Interactionism reminds us that society ultimately exists in the daily interactions of real people, and that meaning is never fixed but always being negotiated.

None of these perspectives is complete on its own. A sociologist who wants to fully understand something like poverty, for instance, would need the macro view of Functionalism to understand what role poverty plays in the economic system, the critical lens of Conflict Theory to examine how power structures perpetuate poverty, and the micro lens of Interactionism to understand how poverty shapes a person's daily interactions, self-image, and social opportunities.

Conclusion

Sociological perspectives are essential tools for understanding the world we live in. When applied to real-world examples, these perspectives stop being abstract academic theories and become powerful tools for making sense of lived experience. Understanding sociology is not just an academic exercise; it is a means of developing the sociological imagination that **C. Wright Mills** described as *the ability to see the connection between personal struggles and the larger social forces that shape them*.

References

- ◆ Macionis, J. J. (2017). Sociology (15th ed.). Pearson Education.
 - ◆ Mills, C. W. (1959). The Sociological Imagination. Oxford University Press.
 - ◆ Ritzer, G., & Stepnisky, J. (2018). Sociological Theory (10th ed.). SAGE Publications.
 - ◆ Chaudhary, F. **Introduction to Sociology – Week 1 Lecture Slides.**
 - ◆ www.slideshare.net/slideshow/major-theoretical-perspectives-in-sociology-14044354/14044354
 - ◆ www.cliffsnotes.com/study-guides/sociology/the-sociological-perspective/three-major-perspectives-in-sociology
-